

Welcome to Magpie

Magpie helps you get organised with the files already on your computer — photos, videos, scans, PDFs, whatever you keep. You point it at a folder, and it shows you every file inside that has room for tags. From there you can:

- Give a file a **name** and add **tags** — short labels like `beach`, `Christmas`, or `contract` — so you can find groups of files in seconds later on.
- Look at everything the file already knows about itself — resolution, camera, when it was taken, page count for PDFs — right next to the file.
- Delete the ones you don't want any more.

Everything stays on your computer. Nothing is uploaded, no account is needed, and you can keep using Magpie with no internet connection.

Why use Magpie?

Most people end up with files scattered across folders like `Camera Roll`, `iPhone Backup 2019`, and `Family - Copy (2)`. Windows gives you those folders and not much more. Magpie gives you a proper way to sort through them:

- **Find things fast.** Type `beach` in the search box and every file you tagged with `beach` shows up, no matter which folder it's in.
- **Nothing gets moved.** Your files stay exactly where they are on disk. Tags are saved *inside* the file itself — in the same standard place Windows Explorer uses — so no extra sidecar files clutter your folders (for the formats that support it).
- **One tool for all your files.** Photos, videos, and documents all live in the same library, side by side, with the same tag search.

A quick tour, in under two minutes

1. **Click “+ Add folder”** at the top of the window and pick a folder full of files. Magpie gets to work reading everything it finds.
2. **Scroll** through the files in the big central area — it stays smooth even with tens of thousands.
3. **Click a file** to open the details panel on the right. Type a title. Add a tag. Everything saves as you go — there's no “Save” button to remember.

4. **Hold Ctrl while clicking** to pick several files at once, then add the same tag to all of them.
5. **Type in the search box** at the top to find files by their tag, title, or filename.

That's the whole app in a nutshell. The rest of this manual explains each part in a bit more detail.

What Magpie is *not*

- **Not an editor.** It won't crop, straighten, retouch, or convert your files. Use another app for that.
- **Not a backup service.** Your files stay on your computer. If your hard drive fails, Magpie can't help — copy your files somewhere safe (an external drive, OneDrive, etc.).
- **Not a face-recogniser.** It won't guess who's in your photos or auto-tag them.

If you want any of those, Magpie is happy to sit next to whichever tool does them for you — it won't get in the way.

Installing and launching Magpie

What you need

- A PC running **Windows 10** or **Windows 11**.
- About **50 MB of free space** for the app.
- A little extra space for small thumbnail images (roughly 100 MB for every 10,000 files).

That's it. No account, no internet connection, no subscription.

Installing

Depending on where you got Magpie from, you'll have one of these:

- **An installer** (a file ending in `.msi` or `.exe`). Double-click it and follow the prompts. When Windows asks whether to allow the installer to make changes, click **Yes**.
- **A portable version** (just `desktop.exe`). Copy it wherever you like — for example, `C:\Programs\Magpie\` — and double-click it to launch. No installation needed.

If Windows shows a blue “Windows protected your PC” screen, click **More info** and then **Run anyway**. This happens with any small app that hasn't paid Microsoft for a code signature — it doesn't mean anything is wrong.

The very first time you open it

When you first start Magpie you'll see:

- An empty window with a friendly **“Add folder”** button.
- The status bar at the bottom saying **Idle**.

Nothing is scanned yet. Nothing is stored yet. Magpie is waiting for you to point it at a folder.

The [next chapter](#) walks you through that in detail.

What Magpie creates on your computer

Magpie keeps its own little workshop in a hidden Windows folder. You don't need to open it or think about it — but if you're curious, it's here:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\
```

That folder contains Magpie's own database (an index of the files it knows about) and small thumbnail previews. **None of your original files live there** — they stay exactly where you put them.

Uninstalling

- Installed with an `.msi` ? Open **Settings > Apps > Installed apps**, find Magpie, and click **Uninstall**.
- Portable version? Just delete `desktop.exe`.

To also wipe Magpie's own files, delete the hidden folder above (in File Explorer, paste `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` into the address bar). **Your files and any tags you added to writable formats are safe** — those live in your folders, not in Magpie's workshop.

Adding your first folder

Magpie needs to know which folders on your computer contain the files you want to organise. Once you tell it, it does the rest.

Add a folder in three clicks

1. Click **+ Add folder** at the top of the window.
2. In the dialog that opens, browse to the folder that has your files — for example `C:\Users\me\Pictures\Vacation 2024`.
3. Click **Select folder**.

That's it. Magpie starts looking through the folder right away. The bar at the bottom of the window shows what's happening ("Reading 234 of 1,205 files...") and updates as it goes.

You don't have to wait for it to finish — files appear in the window as they're found, so you can start browsing (and even tagging) straight away.

What Magpie does when you add a folder

Behind the scenes, Magpie:

- **Looks in the folder and every folder inside it.** So adding `Pictures` also picks up `Pictures\2020`, `Pictures\Kids`, and so on. Video and document files are picked up too — see [Supported file formats](#).
- **Reads the built-in info** each file exposes: dimensions, camera, duration, page count, and so on.
- **Reads any tags or titles** already saved with the file (for example, tags you added earlier in Windows Explorer).
- **Makes small thumbnail previews** for images so the grid loads instantly, even for very large libraries.

Your original files are **not moved, renamed, or changed** in any way during this. Magpie only reads them.

Adding more folders

You can add as many folders as you like — one for your holidays, one for family, one for work documents, whatever suits you.

Every folder you add appears under **Library › Folders** in the left-hand sidebar. Click a folder name there to see only the files inside that folder.

Removing a folder

Right-click the folder name in the sidebar and choose **Remove from library**. Magpie forgets about it — but **your files stay on your computer**. Removing a folder from Magpie is not the same as deleting it from your PC.

Refreshing when files change

If you drop new files into a folder using File Explorer, or edit some in another app, Magpie doesn't know about it right away. To catch up:

- **Right-click a folder name** in the sidebar and choose **Rescan folder**, or
- Click **Rescan** at the top of the window to check every folder at once.

Rescanning is quick — Magpie only looks at files that have changed since the last time it checked.

Browsing your library

The big area in the middle of the window is your **file grid**. It shows every file Magpie knows about, all in one long scrollable page. Even with tens of thousands of files, it stays smooth to scroll.

Picking files

- **Click a file** to select it. It gets a blue outline, and its details appear in the panel on the right.
- **Ctrl + click** more files to add them to the selection.
- **Shift + click** somewhere else in the grid to grab everything between the first and the new click.
- **Ctrl + A** picks every file currently shown.
- **Esc** unpicks everything.

The number of selected files is shown in the panel on the right and in the status bar at the bottom.

Sorting the grid

There's a **Sort** menu in the top bar. Choose what makes sense for the moment:

- **Taken** — when the file was taken/created (from the file itself). Great for going through a trip in order.
- **Filename** — A to Z by name.
- **Added** — the day the file was added to your library.
- **Size** — largest or smallest first.

The little arrow next to the sort menu flips between ascending and descending.

The details panel on the right

Click a file and its details appear on the right, split into four sections:

1. **Title** — a short, editable name.

2. **Tags** — labels you add for grouping and searching.
3. **Format metadata** — which handler Magpie is using and whether it can save your edits into the file itself.
4. **File info** — read-only technical information (size, resolution, camera, duration, page count...). What appears here depends on the file type.

Editing any of the top two sections saves automatically — no Save button. The next chapter, [Editing metadata](#), goes into detail.

If you pick more than one file at once, the details panel switches into a batch mode — see [Working on many files at once](#).

The sidebar filters

The list on the left is a set of filters — clicking one narrows down the grid to just matching files.

- **Library › Folders:** show only files from one specific folder on your computer.
- **Tags:** show only files with a specific tag. The number next to each tag is how many files have that tag.

Filters stack. Click a folder **and** a tag and you see only files that match both. Add words to the search box at the top for even finer results.

Clearing filters

Click **All photos** at the top of the sidebar to start fresh — every filter is cleared in one click.

Searching and filtering

Once you've added tags and titles to a good number of files, finding them again is a treat. Type a word or two in the search box at the top of the window and the grid narrows down to matching files while you type.

What the search looks at

The search box looks in three places on every file:

- The **title** you typed.
- The **tags** you added.
- The **filename** (like `IMG_4523.jpg` or `contract_signed.pdf`).

So if you type `sun`, Magpie finds files titled *Sunset*, tagged `sunny`, or in a file called `sunbathing.jpg`.

Capital letters don't matter: `Beach` and `beach` find the same files. Accents don't matter either: `naïve` finds files where you typed `naïve`.

Handy search tricks

- `beach vacation` — finds files with **both** words somewhere.
- `beach OR mountain` — finds files with **either** word.
- `vacation -beach` — vacation files that are **not** tagged beach.
- `"family reunion"` — the exact phrase, in that order.

You can even start typing part of a word — `sun` matches `sunset`, `sunny`, `sunbathing`.

Search + sidebar filters = laser-focused

The search box works together with the filters on the left. For example, to find *the Iceland files tagged glacier*:

1. Click the folder `Iceland` on the left.
2. Click the `glacier` tag in the Tags list.

The grid updates instantly. When you're done, click **All photos** in the sidebar to reset everything.

Clearing the search

Click the little ✕ inside the search box to clear it — or press **Esc** while your cursor is inside the box. The sidebar filters stay where they were.

Nothing found?

If a search turns up empty and you were expecting results:

- Check for a typo. `caht` won't find `cat` files.
- Try a shorter word. `mount` finds both `mountain` and `mountains`.
- Check the sidebar — you might have a filter active (like a folder or tag) that's excluding matches. Click **All photos** and try the search again.

Editing metadata

Metadata is a fancy word for “information about a file” — its title and tags. It’s what makes a folder of `IMG_1234.jpg` and `document_final_v3.pdf` files feel like a real library.

To edit any of this, click one file in the grid. The **details panel** on the right lights up with everything you can change.

What the panel shows

The details panel is split into four sections, top to bottom:

1. **Title** — a short, editable name (e.g. “Anna’s birthday cake”).
2. **Tags** — little labels like `beach`, `family`, `2024`, `contract`.
3. **Format metadata** — which handler Magpie is using for this file (JPEG, PNG, PDF, MP4, ...) and whether Magpie can save your edits directly into the file.
4. **File info** — everything Magpie learned from the file itself: size, resolution, when it was taken, camera used, page count, video duration, and so on. This section is read-only — those numbers describe the file, not your notes about it.

Everything saves as you type

There is **no Save button**. Magpie saves your changes automatically:

- **Title**: saved a moment after you stop typing (or as soon as you click somewhere else).
- **Tags**: saved immediately once you press space, Enter or comma.

You’ll see a tiny “Saving...” note when it’s happening. It usually takes less than half a second.

Setting a title

Click the **Title** box, type a name, click somewhere else (or wait a moment). Done.

To clear a title, just erase what’s there.

Adding tags

Click the **Tags** box. Type a word — for example `family` — and then press one of:

- **Space**
- **Enter**
- **Comma**

The tag becomes a little pill you can see. Type another word, press space, and there's another. Keep going for as many tags as you want.

While you type, Magpie suggests tags you've already used elsewhere, so you don't end up with `Beach`, `beach`, and `beaches` all meaning the same thing. Use the arrow keys to pick a suggestion and press Enter.

To **remove a tag**, hover over its pill and click the little ✕.

Where the tags actually live

Magpie always saves your tags into its **library index** so search and filtering stay fast — even for files on drives that aren't plugged in right now.

On top of that, Magpie also tries to save your tags **inside the file itself**. There are three possible outcomes, and the tag editor tells you which one is happening for the file you're looking at:

1. **Embedded directly by Magpie (XMP).** For JPEG, PNG, WebP and GIF89a, Magpie writes the tags right into the image file using the industry-standard *XMP* slot. Adobe Bridge, Lightroom, Photos, and File Explorer all see them.

Title and tags are embedded directly into the JPG file (XMP).

2. **Saved by Windows on Magpie's behalf.** For RAW photos (CR2/CR3/NEF/ARW/DNG/RAF/RW2/...), HEIC/HEIF/AVIF, TIFF, MP4/MOV/M4V/3GP, WMV/ASF, and JPEG XR/JXR, Magpie hands the tags to the exact same Windows property system that Explorer's *Properties* → *Details* tab uses. Anything you tag in Magpie shows up in Explorer immediately, and vice-versa.

Title and tags are saved on the source file via the same Windows property system that Explorer's Properties → Details tab uses.

3. **Library-only (fallback).** A handful of formats have no writable property handler on Windows — BMP, DIB, SVG, EXR, HDR, JPEG 2000, PSD, and older MPEG-TS variants are the main ones. Your tags are still saved in Magpie's library, but they won't travel with the file if you copy it elsewhere.

Windows has no property handler that can embed tags in BMP files on this system, so tags are stored in Magpie's library only.

See [Supported file formats](#) for the full per-format table.

If a save fails

If Windows or the file itself rejects the write (usually because the file is read-only, on a locked drive, or open in another program), the panel shows a red note under the Tags field:

Save failed: *(the exact error from Windows)*

Fix the underlying problem — close the other program, take the file off read-only, or move it somewhere writable — and re-edit the tag. Magpie's library is *not* updated for a failed save, so no state is ever silently out of sync.

Working on many files at once

Editing files one at a time is fine when there are only a few. But when you have hundreds — say, an entire holiday — you'll want to tag them all in one go. Magpie is built for exactly that.

Picking several files

- **Click** the first file.
- **Ctrl + click** each of the other files you want to include.
- Or **Shift + click** at the far end to grab everything in between.
- **Ctrl + A** grabs every file in the current view.

The details panel on the right immediately switches to a batch view that reads *"N files selected"*. The number ticks up as you add more.

Adding tags to all of them

Batch mode shows two tag boxes:

- **Add tags** — anything you put here gets added to every selected file. Files that already had the tag are simply left alone.
- **Remove tags** — anything you put here gets removed from every selected file.

You can queue up multiple tags before hitting the button. When you're ready, click **Apply tag changes to N files**. A confirmation appears when it's done: *"Updated N files."*

Tip. Add tags in bulk first, then use the sidebar to check your work. Click the tag on the left — the grid narrows to just the files that have it, and you can see whether everything landed correctly.

Deleting them all at once

At the bottom of the details panel there's a red **Delete N files** button. Click it, confirm the prompt, and the whole selection heads to the Recycle Bin. See [Deleting files](#) for the full story.

What if one file won't accept a change?

Two cases where a file gets skipped:

1. **The folder is read-only** (an old backup drive, or something you pulled off a DVD). Fix the permissions on that folder (right-click → *Properties* in File Explorer) and try again.
2. **The file's format doesn't support embedded tags yet** (RAW, HEIC, PDF, video...). Magpie still remembers the tag in its own library, but it can't write it back into the file. The rest of the batch gets updated normally.

Either way, Magpie shows a message at the end telling you which files were skipped and why.

Tags: adding, renaming, cleaning up

Tags are little labels you stick on files so you can find them later. There are no folders-inside-folders or complicated structures — tags are just words. A file can have as many as you want.

Good tags are things you'd naturally think of later:

- **Places:** Iceland, beach, home.
- **People:** Emma, Grandad, the twins.
- **Events:** wedding, Christmas-2024, hike.
- **Feelings:** favourites, funny, to-print.

Adding tags

The most detailed walkthrough is in [Editing metadata](#). In short:

- Click the **Tags** box in the details panel.
- Type a word.
- Press **Space**, **Enter**, or **Comma** to save it.

Repeat as many times as you like. To **remove** a tag, click the little ✕ on its pill.

Capital letters don't matter — Beach and beach are treated as the same tag.

The tag list in the sidebar

Every tag you've ever used shows up in the **Tags** section of the sidebar on the left, in alphabetical order. Next to each tag is a number — how many files carry that tag.

- **Click a tag** to filter the grid to only files with that tag.
- **Right-click a tag** for two options: **Rename** and **Delete**.

Renaming a tag

Made a typo? Change your mind on capitalisation? Right-click the tag and choose **Rename tag**.... Type the new name and confirm.

Magpie updates the tag on **every file that had it**, all at once. There's no per-file work to do.

Deleting a tag

Right-click the tag → **Delete tag**. This removes the tag from every file — but it does not delete any files. Only the label goes.

Autocompletion — save yourself typos

While you type a new tag, Magpie shows a small dropdown of tags you've used before that start with the same letters. Use the arrow keys to pick one and press Enter. This is the easiest way to keep your tag list tidy — no more `beach`, `beaches`, `beach`, `beach-day`.

Tips for tagging a big library

- **Start broad.** Tag by place or year first — `Iceland`, `2024`. Once every file has broad tags, narrow ones (`glacier`, `Reykjavik`) are easier because you can filter down first.
- **Use multi-select.** `Ctrl + click` many files and add tags to them all in one go.
- **Don't over-tag.** A tag that's on 8,000 files isn't very useful. When in doubt, pick tags that would show fewer than a few hundred results.

Do tags show up in other apps?

For the formats Magpie can write into (JPEG, PNG, WebP, GIF), yes — tags are saved in the same standard XMP format that Windows Explorer, Adobe Lightroom, and other tools use. See [Interoperability with other tools](#) for the details.

For read-only formats (RAW, HEIC, PDF, video, ...) tags live in Magpie's library only. See [Supported file formats](#) for the current list.

Supported file formats

Magpie can put every kind of file below into your library and let you tag and search it. The difference between the categories is whether Magpie can **save your tags into the file itself** or just **remember them in the library**.

The upside of saving tags into the file is that they follow the file around — copy it to another computer, upload it to a cloud folder, send it to a friend, and the tags come along. The downside is that Magpie has to know how to write into the file’s format, and some formats are trickier than others.

Files where Magpie can save tags into the file

Magpie writes titles and tags using **two** mechanisms, whichever fits the file best:

- For a small set of image formats Magpie writes the tags itself, using the industry-standard **XMP** metadata packet that Adobe Lightroom, digiKam, and Windows Explorer all understand.
- For everything else, Magpie asks **Windows** to do it, using the exact same code path as the *Properties* → *Details* dialog you can open by right-clicking a file in Explorer.

That means: **if Windows Explorer can set tags on a file, Magpie can too.**

Magpie writes directly (XMP)

These four containers Magpie writes into by itself, using the industry-standard **XMP** slot. Works on any OS, regardless of what Windows codec packs happen to be installed.

Format	Extensions	Notes
JPEG	.jpg, .jpeg, .jpe, .jfif	The most common photo format.
PNG	.png	Great for screenshots and lossless images.
WebP	.webp	Modern web-friendly format.
GIF	.gif	GIF89a only; old GIF87a files can’t hold tags.

Windows writes for us (Shell property system)

For every other format below Magpie asks Windows to save the tags, using the exact same code path Explorer's *Properties* → *Details* dialog uses. Verified working on a stock Windows 11 install:

- **Camera RAW** — `.cr2`, `.cr3`, `.crw` (Canon), `.nef`, `.nrw` (Nikon), `.arw`, `.sr2`, `.srf` (Sony), `.raf` (Fuji), `.orf`, `.ori` (Olympus), `.rw2`, `.rw1` (Panasonic), `.pef` (Pentax), `.srw` (Samsung), `.dng` (Adobe/generic), `.x3f` (Sigma).
- **Modern HEIF family** — `.heic`, `.heif`, `.hif`, `.avif`.
- **TIFF family** — `.tif`, `.tiff`.
- **JPEG XL / JPEG XR / HD Photo** — `.jxl`, `.jxr`, `.wdp`.
- **Video / MP4 family** — `.mp4`, `.m4v`, `.mov`, `.3gp`, `.3gpp`, `.3g2`.
- **Legacy Windows video / audio** — `.wmv`, `.asf`.

If the tag editor is enabled and you don't see the amber warning below the tag box, Windows agreed to save into the file. You can double-check by right-clicking the file in Explorer and opening *Properties* → *Details*.

Files Magpie remembers but doesn't tag inside

The following formats have no writable property handler on a stock Windows 11 install — Magpie still lets you tag them, but the tags live in the Magpie library only:

- **Raster with no keyword support** — `.bmp`, `.dib`, `.svg`, `.exr`, `.hdr`, `.hdp`.
- **JPEG 2000 family** — `.jp2`, `.j2k`, `.j2c`, `.jpx`, `.jif`.
- **Photoshop** — `.psd`, `.psb` (*no keyword-writable handler registered by Windows; Photoshop itself does write, but its handler doesn't expose `System.Keywords`*).
- **PDF** — `.pdf` (*depends on the installed reader — Adobe Reader DC registers a writable handler, most other viewers don't*).
- **MPEG transport / Matroska / MP2** — `.ts`, `.mts`, `.m2ts`, `.mkv`, `.mks`, `.mka`, `.webm`, `.avi`, `.qt`.
- **Sony pixel-shift RAW** — `.arq`.

For these Magpie stores tags **only in its library index**. Search and filtering still work; the tag just won't follow the file if you copy it elsewhere. The tag editor shows a short amber note whenever this happens.

The list above reflects a stock Windows 11 24H2 install. If you install a third-party codec pack (e.g. Adobe DNG Codec, Panasonic RAW codec, PDF-XChange), Magpie automatically

starts writing into those formats — no configuration required. Restart Magpie once after installing a new codec so the capability cache refreshes.

Files Magpie ignores

Anything not in the tables above is skipped when you scan a folder. That's intentional — a system file or ZIP archive doesn't usually belong in a photo/video library.

If you want a new file type supported, that's a normal thing to ask for. The Magpie backend has a small “format handler” plug-in system so new types can be added without touching the rest of the app.

Deleting files

Sooner or later you'll want to get rid of some files — blurry shots, duplicates, an old draft PDF, that photo of a light switch from someone's pocket. Magpie deletes them safely, with a confirmation, and puts them in the **Recycle Bin** so you can undo the deletion if you change your mind.

Deleting one file

1. Click the file in the grid.
2. Either:
 - Click the red **Delete file** button at the bottom of the details panel, **or**
 - Press the **Delete** key on your keyboard.
3. A prompt asks: *"Move IMG_2043.jpg to the Recycle Bin?"*.
4. Click **Move to Recycle Bin** to confirm — or **Cancel** to back out.

The file disappears from Magpie and lands in the Windows Recycle Bin.

Deleting many files at once

1. Pick lots of files with **Ctrl + click** or **Shift + click**.
2. Click **Delete N files** at the bottom of the details panel (or press the **Delete** key).
3. Confirm the prompt.

What actually happens when you delete

- The file is moved to the **Windows Recycle Bin** — the same Recycle Bin you already know.
- Any tags Magpie had for that file go with it.
- Any leftover `.xmp` sidecar next to the file is deleted too.
- Magpie forgets the file (until you restore it — see below).

Nothing is deleted permanently — unless you tell it to (see the next section).

Getting a file back after deleting

Made a mistake? No problem:

1. Double-click the **Recycle Bin** on your desktop.
2. Find your file.
3. Right-click it → **Restore**.

The file goes back exactly where it was. The next time you click **Rescan** in Magpie, it re-appears in the library with its tags and title still on it.

Permanently deleting (no safety net)

If you're absolutely sure a file is gone-for-good, hold the **Shift** key while pressing Delete (or while clicking the delete button). The prompt will say *"Permanently delete"* instead of *"Move to Recycle Bin"*.

Warning. Permanent deletion cannot be undone. Do not use it unless you're 100% sure — and always keep a backup of important files.

If in doubt, use the normal delete. You can always empty the Recycle Bin later.

What is *not* deleted

- **Removing a folder from Magpie is not deleting.** The files stay on your computer.
- **Un-tagging is not deleting.** Removing every tag from a file just leaves it un-tagged.
- **A tag that no file uses any more** doesn't get deleted automatically. You can right-click it in the sidebar and choose **Delete tag** to clean it up.

Where your data lives

A quick, plain-language tour of what Magpie puts where. You don't need to know any of this to use the app — but many people like knowing exactly where their information ends up.

Your files

Your files stay where you put them. Magpie never moves, renames, or changes them (except to write tags into ones that support it — see below). If you added

`C:\Users\me\Pictures\Vacation 2024`, that's where the files still live.

Your tags and titles

Whenever you tag a file or give it a title, Magpie tries to save that **inside the file itself**, using the standard XMP metadata format that Windows Explorer, Adobe Lightroom, and other tools also understand. A tag you add in Magpie immediately shows up in File Explorer's *Details* tab.

Right now Magpie can embed tags into:

- **JPEG** (`.jpg`, `.jpeg`)
- **PNG** (`.png`)
- **WebP** (`.webp`)
- **GIF** (`.gif`, GIF89a only)

Your files still open and look exactly the same — only a small note about the file is added.

No sidcar files. Magpie does **not** create any extra `.xmp` files next to your files. Everything lives inside the file itself.

File types where tags stay in Magpie only

For everything else (RAW, HEIC, TIFF, PDF, video, ...) Magpie **still lets you tag the file** — the tag just gets remembered in Magpie's own library instead of embedded in the file. See [Supported file formats](#) for the full list.

The trade-off: those tags are visible everywhere in Magpie, but if you copy the file to another computer they don't come along.

Legacy .xmp files

If you used an older version of Magpie or Adobe Lightroom, some of your files may already have a small `.xmp` companion file next to them. Magpie still **reads** those on first scan so you don't lose your existing tags. As soon as you save an edit to that file, Magpie embeds the new tags into the file itself and **deletes the leftover `.xmp` file** — from then on the file is the single source of truth.

Magpie's own workshop

Magpie keeps its own private files in a hidden Windows folder:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\
```

That folder has:

- A little database that remembers what's in your library, so opening the app is instant.
- Tags for read-only formats (RAW, HEIC, PDF, video, ...) that can't be embedded in the source file.
- Small thumbnail images so the grid loads without delay.
- A log file that helps if you ever run into trouble.

None of your original files live in this folder. You can delete the whole folder if you want — Magpie will just re-scan your library next time. Tags on read-only formats will be lost.

The three golden rules

1. **Magpie never moves your files.** They stay in the folders where you put them.
2. **Magpie never uploads anything.** No internet, no cloud, no account.
3. **For writable formats, tags live inside the file.** So if you copy a JPEG or PNG to another computer, its tags come along for the ride — no extra files needed.

Backing up

To back up your library:

1. **Back up your file folders.** Tags for JPEG/PNG/WebP/GIF are inside the files themselves — that covers most photos.
2. **Also back up Magpie's workshop folder** if you tagged read-only files (RAW, PDF, video...) — those tags live only there.

So “copy my Pictures folder and `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` to a backup drive” is a complete backup.

Working with other tools

Your tags and titles aren't locked inside Magpie. For file formats Magpie can write into (JPEG, PNG, WebP, GIF), Magpie saves them the standard way — inside the file itself — so other tools can read them too, and Magpie can read tags added by other tools.

Windows Explorer

- **Tags you add in Magpie show up in Explorer.** Right-click a file → **Properties** → **Details** tab. Your tags are in the *Tags* row and your title in *Title*.
- **Tags you add in Explorer show up in Magpie.** After you type a tag in Explorer's Details tab, click **Rescan** in Magpie (or wait for the next time you click that file). The tag appears.

Note. Explorer caches things aggressively. If a tag you just added isn't showing, press F5 in the folder or navigate away and back.

Windows Photos app

The built-in Photos app reads titles that Magpie wrote. Not all metadata is editable there, but you'll see it.

Adobe Lightroom, Adobe Bridge, digiKam

These are photo tools used by pros and enthusiasts. All of them read the same XMP tag/title format Magpie uses. So a library you tag in Magpie opens up in Lightroom with everything already labelled — and vice versa. Any star ratings or captions those tools wrote are **preserved** by Magpie when it saves your edits, even though the current Magpie UI doesn't show them.

Some tools cache their view of a folder. If your changes aren't appearing, use the "refresh" or "reload metadata" option in the other tool.

Other tools

Many smaller viewers (XnView, FastStone, IrfanView, and so on) can read tags in this standard format too. If your tool has a “read XMP metadata” option, turn it on.

What if I tag a RAW file, HEIC, PDF, or video?

Some file formats don’t have a safe standard way for Magpie to embed tags inside them yet, so **for these files Magpie stores your tags in its own library only**. The tag will still appear in Magpie — the file itself is left untouched.

See [Supported file formats](#) for the full read-only list. If you shoot RAW+JPEG, Magpie can tag the JPEG version instead, and those tags are then visible in Windows Explorer, Lightroom, and every other standard tool.

Migrating from an older Magpie or Lightroom

Earlier Magpie versions (and Adobe Lightroom for RAW files) sometimes left small `.xmp` companion files next to your files. Magpie still reads those on first scan, so you keep your existing tags — but the first time you save an edit, Magpie embeds the tags into the file itself and removes the leftover `.xmp`. From that point on, the file is the only place your tags live.

In short

If your other tool speaks the standard XMP metadata language (and almost every modern one does), it reads and writes the same tags and titles Magpie does — as long as the file format allows embedded XMP. You can move between tools freely without losing your work.

Keyboard shortcuts

You can do everything in Magpie with a mouse, but keyboard shortcuts make the whole thing much faster once you know them.

Picking files

Shortcut	What it does
Click	Pick one file
Ctrl + Click	Add or remove one file from your selection
Shift + Click	Pick everything between the last click and this one
Ctrl + A	Pick every file in the current view
Esc	Unpick everything

Moving around

Shortcut	What it does
Arrow keys	Move the cursor around the grid
Home / End	Jump to the first / last file
Page Up / Page Down	Jump one screen up or down

Titles and tags

Shortcut	What it does
Tab (in the title)	Save what you typed and move to the next field
Enter (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed

Shortcut	What it does
Space (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed
Comma (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed
Backspace (empty tag box)	Remove the last tag you added

Everyday actions

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + F	Jump to the search box at the top
Ctrl + R	Refresh every folder in your library
Delete	Send the selected files to the Recycle Bin
Shift + Delete	Delete the selected files permanently
F1	Open this manual

Layout

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + B	Show or hide the left-hand sidebar
Ctrl + D	Show or hide the details panel on the right
F11	Full-screen mode (great for browsing)

Troubleshooting

Most bumps you'll hit fall into one of the buckets below. If none of these matches your problem, Magpie keeps a diary in a log file that can help — the last section explains where to find it.

The app won't open

What happens: You double-click Magpie and either nothing happens or you get a “WebView2” error message.

Fix: Install the free **Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime** from Microsoft's website. It's a small download. Windows 11 already has it; Windows 10 usually gets it automatically through Windows Update.

Tags I added in File Explorer don't show up in Magpie

What happens: You right-click a file in File Explorer, add a tag under **Properties › Details**, but Magpie's sidebar doesn't list it.

Why: Magpie only re-reads tags when you tell it to (or when you click the file). It doesn't watch your folders in the background.

Fix: Click **Rescan** at the top of Magpie, or right-click the folder in the sidebar and choose **Rescan folder**. The tag will appear.

Tags I added in Magpie don't show up in File Explorer

What happens: You add a tag in Magpie, open the file's properties in File Explorer, and the Tags row is empty.

Fixes to try, in order:

1. **Refresh the Explorer window.** Press **F5** or navigate away and back. Explorer likes to hold onto old data.

2. **Check the file format.** Only formats that Magpie can write into propagate tags to Explorer — see [Supported file formats](#). Convert to JPEG or PNG if you need Explorer to see the tag.
 3. **Check the folder isn't read-only.** If the folder is on a read-only drive (like a locked backup), Magpie can't save inside the file. Right-click the folder → **Properties** and make sure *Read-only* is off.
-

Files are missing from the grid

What happens: A folder has 500 files in File Explorer but only 480 appear in Magpie.

Common reasons:

- **Unusual file formats.** Magpie handles the ones listed on [Supported file formats](#). Others are skipped.
 - **Hidden files.** Files marked as Hidden or System in Windows are skipped on purpose.
 - **A previous scan hit an error.** Right-click the folder → **Rescan folder** to try again.
-

The app is slow / the grid stutters

What to try:

- **Wait for the first scan.** The very first time Magpie reads a folder it works your CPU hard making thumbnails. Give it a few minutes. Next time you open the app, it'll be instant.
 - **Close other heavy apps.** Magpie uses your graphics card to draw the grid smoothly. If another app is eating that up, both apps suffer.
 - **Restart Magpie.** Sometimes the simplest fix.
-

“Save failed” message

What happens: After clicking **Apply tag changes to N files**, a red **Save failed** message pops up.

Fix: Two common causes:

1. **Folder permissions.** One of the files lives on a network drive or locked backup. Check that you can write to that folder in File Explorer, then try again.
2. **The file is in a format Magpie can't tag inside yet.** For those, the tag lives in Magpie's library only, but the batch won't show a red error — it just skips the file with a note.

The log file (see below) will tell you exactly which file failed.

“This format can't store Magpie tags inside the file”

What happens: You try to edit a `.cr2` RAW file or a `.heic` photo and get this message.

Why: Only a handful of image formats (JPEG, PNG, WebP, GIF89a) have a safe, standard way to embed tags. Magpie won't create hidden `.xmp` companion files, so if it can't put your edit *inside* the file, it won't pretend to save it there.

Workarounds:

- Tag the file anyway — it works. The tag is remembered in Magpie's library. It just won't travel with the file to another computer.
 - Or convert (or export a copy of) the file to JPEG/PNG/WebP/GIF and tag that copy.
 - If you shoot RAW+JPEG, tag the JPEG version — Lightroom, Bridge, and other tools will read those tags too.
-

Resetting Magpie

If Magpie gets into a weird state and you want to start fresh:

1. Close Magpie.
2. Open File Explorer, paste `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` into the address bar, and press Enter.
3. Delete that folder.
4. Reopen Magpie — it starts empty and you can add your folders again.

Your files and any tags saved inside them are all safe — those live in your folders, not in the folder you just deleted. Tags that Magpie only kept in its own library are lost, so this is a proper reset.

Finding the log file

Magpie keeps a diary of everything it does at:

```
%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app\logs\app.log
```

Open it in Notepad. The bottom of the file is the most recent activity. Lines beginning with **WARN** or **ERROR** are the interesting ones if something went wrong. This is the file to share (or paste into) if you ever report a bug.